#AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON, ELECTIONS DEVELOPMENT HUB AND ELECTORAL COMMUNITY OF PRACTICE.

Electoral Technology, Trustworthy Electoral Information, Digital Literacy and Inclusive Participation

CONCEPT DOCUMENT

Application Opens from Midnight – Thursday, 22nd October 2026

Application Duration – Thursday, 22nd October to Thursday - 12th November 2026 at 11:59pm WAT

Project Period - October 2026 - February 2027

Format - National, Multidisciplinary and Nonpartisan, Sustainable long-term Strategy

A Project of Rise Networks in collaboration with Technical Private Sector Partners and Relevant Public Agencies.

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Following the success of Run-Am, an AI-powered misinformation detection and fact-checking mobile app developed by Rise Networks for the 2023 Nigerian elections and several months of discussions and consultations with **Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC), Rise Networks**, in collaboration with its partners including the **International Centre for Investigative Reporting (ICIR)**, **Google**, **Microsoft**, **Meta**, **NITHUB at the University of Lagos**, **the Centre for Information Technology and Development (CITAD)**, **CLEEN Foundation**, **Tap Initiative for Citizens' Development**, **International Press Centre (IPC)**, **Legal Naija, Ahmadu Bello University** and **Federal University of Akure (FUTA)**, with support from the **MacArthur Foundation** and **Luminate**, invites eligible Nigerians to apply for the **#AI4Elections Hackathon**, a national,

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multidisciplinary and nonpartisan programme designed to bring together Nigeria's technology ecosystem, electoral experts, researchers, universities, developers, innovators and civil society to design and develop practical, responsible technology solutions for electoral integrity, transparency, inclusion and democratic participation. The Programme embodies an open innovation challenge, team formation, mentorship, technical development, prototype testing, judging and usability/penetration/pilot testing for and beyond the 2027 elections cycle.

As artificial intelligence becomes increasingly influential in information production, digital communications, public administration and civic participation, there's a growing need for practical, evidence-based and responsible tech especially AI Solutions, that can strengthen electoral integrity, improve access to reliable information, support transparency and expand inclusion. Nigeria's electoral environment presents an opportunity to bring together technical talent and electoral expertise to develop solutions that respond to real-world challenges, while protecting fundamental rights, privacy, institutional independence and public trust. The #AI4Elections Hackathon will provide a structured platform for participants to identify electoral challenges, collaborate across disciplines, develop and demonstrate working prototypes, conduct research and develop technology-enabled approaches to electoral innovation. Our implementation model for this Project is that Rise Networks will build a large national pipeline of technical talent and prototypes that'll develop practical, responsible and election-safe AI solutions for Nigeria, INEC provides institutional guidance on the guardrails and feedback, our civil society and private sector technology partners contribute infrastructure, standardization, technical support, and donors and corporate organizations provide acceleration capital.

The Project will be delivered through three connected pillars:

i. *The* #AI4Elections *Hackathon* - the national competition and innovation showcase.

ii. *The* #AI4Elections *Development Hub* - a post-hackathon incubation and validation programme.

iii. *The #AI4Elections Community of Practice* - a sustained non-partisan national network of innovators, developers, researchers, universities, electoral experts, civic organisations and tech partners working on the responsible use of AI and technology for electoral integrity, inclusion and ethical public participation.

Rise Networks is the project initiator and owner. INEC, relevant public institutions, universities, technology companies, civil society organisations and development partners are welcome to participate in appropriate institutional, technical, research, mentorship and partnership capacities. The inaugural edition of the #AI4Elections Hackathon begins on the 8th of October 2026, culminating in a national finals and prize giving ceremony in Abuja in December 2026 followed by a structured incubation and institutional engagement programme. The ultimate objective is to establish a recurring Nigerian platform for developing responsible electoral technology, strengthening national AI talent and supporting public-interest innovation beyond a single electoral cycle.

2. BACKGROUND AND RATIONALE

Artificial intelligence is transforming the way people access information, communicate, analyse data and interact with public institutions. Its applications offer opportunities for improving public services and civic participation, but also introduce risks relating to synthetic media, misinformation, privacy, cybersecurity, algorithmic bias and the manipulation of information environments. Elections are particularly sensitive to these developments because they depend on public confidence, accurate information, institutional accountability, transparent processes and the ability of citizens to participate freely. Nigeria has a growing ecosystem of technology entrepreneurs, AI researchers, university-based innovators, software developers, data scientists and civic technology organisations but the people developing technology and the people with deep knowledge of electoral processes do not always have structured opportunities to work together. The **#AI4Elections** Hackathon seeks to bridge this gap as it will connect electoral problem owners and subject-matter experts with technical talent, enabling teams to move from problem identification to research, prototyping, testing and potential implementation.

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The Hackathon is not intended to develop partisan campaign technology, influence voter preferences or interfere with electoral administration. It is designed to support nonpartisan, public-interest innovation that respects electoral law, democratic rights and responsible AI principles. By creating a structured pipeline for talent development, prototype evaluation, research and institutional engagement, Rise Networks aims to contribute to a stronger ecosystem for responsible electoral technology in Nigeria.

3. PROGRAMME GOAL

Goal: To establish a national platform that mobilises Nigerian and Africa-connected talent to develop, test and promote responsible AI and emerging technology solutions for trustworthy elections, transparency, inclusion and democratic participation.

4. OBJECTIVES

This Programme seeks to:

1. Identify and support practical AI and technology solutions addressing clearly defined electoral challenges.
2. Mobilise multidisciplinary talent from universities, technology companies, research institutions, startups and civil society.
3. Strengthen technical capacity in AI engineering, data science, cybersecurity, electoral technology, responsible AI and civic innovation.
4. Encourage evidence-based research into the opportunities, risks and governance implications of AI in elections.
5. Facilitate collaboration between innovators and relevant electoral, academic, public-sector and civil society stakeholders.
6. Establish a national database and sustained community of electoral innovators, researchers, developers, mentors and institutional partners.
7. Support promising prototypes through incubation, technical validation, mentorship and potential institutional pilots, subject to relevant approvals.
8. Produce practical research, policy recommendations and an annual electoral innovation report.

5. PROGRAMME CORE & SUSTAINABILITY STRATEGY

The **#AI4Elections** Hackathon 2026 - 2027 is conceived not as a standalone competition, but as the foundation of a sustainable, multi-year national platform for responsible artificial intelligence, electoral innovation and democratic participation in Nigeria. Following the conclusion of the inaugural edition, Rise Networks will work with its partners to establish a structured post-hackathon pathway through which promising solutions will receive continued technical mentorship, product refinement, incubation support, infrastructure access and opportunities for responsible piloting and deployment, subject to appropriate institutional approvals. The Programme will also seek to establish an enduring #AI4Elections community of developers, researchers, university students, civic innovators and technology entrepreneurs, supported by continuous capacity-building programmes, research collaborations, knowledge-sharing activities and partnerships with technology companies, academic institutions, electoral stakeholders and development organisations. Through subsequent annual editions, strategic partner commitments, institutional collaboration, resource mobilisation and the development of an #AI4Elections research and knowledge platform, Rise Networks plans to build a sustainable national ecosystem that continuously develops locally relevant AI solutions, strengthens Nigeria's electoral technology capacity and contributes to more inclusive, transparent, accessible and accountable democratic processes. The long-term ambition is to establish #AI4Elections as a recognised African platform for responsible electoral AI innovation, with the capacity to support research, talent development, technology testing and cross-country knowledge exchange across the continent.

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The Key Pillars of this Programme

Pillars	Activities
Pillar 1 - #AI4Elections Hackathon	National open call, team formation, bootcamps, innovation challenges, prototype development, judging, awards and grand finale.
Pillar 2 - #AI4Elections Development Hub	Post-hackathon incubation, technical testing, safety reviews, mentorship, product refinement, research development and potential institutional pilots.
Pillar 3 - #AI4Elections Community	National registry, university chapters, technical and research sessions, mentorship network, alumni engagement and continuing innovation challenges. These pillars are designed as a connected programme, and the hackathon is expected to identify talent and promising solutions; the Development Hub will support selected projects; and the community will sustain participation and collaboration over time.

6. #AI4ELECTIONS HACKATHON TRACKS

The inaugural edition of the #AI4Elections Hackathon 2026 - 2027 will feature five principal challenge areas designed to mobilise Nigerian innovators, technologists, researchers and elections-minded young people to develop responsible, practical and human-centred AI solutions for electoral and civic processes. The Hackathon will prioritise non-sensitive electoral use cases, publicly available information and authorised datasets, with an emphasis on voter education, accessibility, information integrity, operational efficiency, public understanding and citizen accountability.

Challenge statements were developed in consultation with relevant subject-matter experts and institutional partners, and Institutional engagement does not constitute endorsement, procurement commitment or a guarantee of adoption or deployment. All participating teams must comply with applicable data-protection, privacy, cybersecurity and responsible-AI requirements. Solutions must preserve human oversight and must not interfere with legally authorised electoral processes or critical election infrastructure.

Track 1: AI and Trustworthy Electoral Information

We anticipate solutions for detecting, assessing and responding to AI-generated or manipulated electoral information, synthetic media, impersonation and misleading content. Outputs are expected to include information verification tools, provenance systems, multilingual fact-checking assistance and responsible information-analysis systems.

Track 2: Electoral Data Analysis, Operational Insights & Decision Support

We anticipate solutions for responsible AI applications for analysing authorised electoral datasets, improving data quality, processing public documents, supporting logistics analysis and identifying data anomalies for human review. Solutions must not independently declare electoral results or substitute algorithmic outputs for legally authorised electoral processes.

Track 3: Inclusive and Multilingual Electoral/Civic Technology

We anticipate solutions for accessible voter-information tools, Nigerian-language electoral and civic information, assistive interfaces for people with disabilities, digital literacy solutions and technology addressing barriers to electoral participation.

Track 4: Electoral Cybersecurity and Resilience

We anticipate solutions for defensive tools, authorised simulations, security monitoring concepts, privacy-preserving systems and resilience approaches for electoral technology. No testing of live electoral systems or unauthorised access to institutional infrastructure will be permitted. This track specifically invites participants to develop responsible, defensive and privacy-

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preserving technologies that can strengthen cybersecurity awareness, digital resilience, secure information management and the protection of electoral and civic technology environments. Solutions may include defensive security monitoring concepts, secure-by-design applications, privacy-preserving systems, incident reporting and response tools, cybersecurity awareness platforms, security training resources, authorised simulations and resilience models for electoral technology. Participants may also develop tools for identifying common security weaknesses in their own applications, improving secure software development practices, supporting incident documentation, or modelling potential operational disruptions using synthetic datasets and isolated test environments.

Track 5: Election Observation and Citizen Accountability

We anticipate solutions such as tools for structured observation reporting, incident documentation, civic feedback, public information access and transparency, with appropriate safeguards for observers and citizens. Final problem statements will be developed with relevant subject-matter experts and prospective institutional partners. Participation by an institution will not imply endorsement of any solution.

The Programme welcomes responsible innovation, particularly where technology can contribute to voter education, accessibility, operational efficiency, public information and greater citizen understanding of the electoral process. Participants are encouraged to develop solutions for improving voter education, simplifying electoral information, improving accessibility, helping citizens locate and understand publicly available electoral information, supporting election training, analysing publicly available election data, or modelling election logistics using simulated datasets. Where data is required, the preference should be for publicly available, anonymised, aggregated or synthetic data.

Climate Resilience and Environmental Innovation: An Optional Crosscutting Area

#AI4Elections invites applicants to explore how AI and digital technologies can address climate-related challenges that affect elections, civic participation, access to information and public accountability. Climate resilience is **not a separate Hackathon track**. It is an optional application area that may be incorporated into any of the five existing challenge tracks.

Applicants interested in this area may develop solutions such as:

- **Electoral accessibility and climate risks:** Tools that use public weather, flood-risk or geographic data to help communities and relevant stakeholders understand potential barriers to accessing civic or electoral information.
- **Climate misinformation and information integrity:** AI-assisted tools for assessing misleading environmental claims, manipulated climate-related content or misinformation connected to public policy and electoral discussions.
- **Environmental accountability:** Applications that help citizens and researchers analyse publicly available information about environmental projects, climate-related government commitments or public expenditure.
- **Inclusive civic information:** Multilingual, accessible and low-bandwidth tools that help communities access relevant civic information during environmental disruptions or in areas with limited digital infrastructure.
- **Climate-aware technology:** Responsible AI solutions designed to be resource-efficient and usable in communities' facing energy, connectivity or infrastructure constraints.

What applicants should demonstrate

Climate-related submissions must:

1. Identify a specific electoral, civic participation, information integrity or public-accountability problem that has a meaningful climate or environmental dimension.
2. Explain how the proposed AI or digital technology addresses that problem and who benefits from the solution.
3. Identify the data sources to be used and demonstrate responsible data handling, privacy and security.

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4. Explain how the solution will remain accessible, usable and responsible in the intended context.
5. Demonstrate that the proposed solution complements, rather than replaces, established electoral and institutional processes.

Climate innovation proposals that do not have a clear connection to the objectives and challenge tracks of AI4Elections will not qualify under this cross-cutting application area. Applicants are not required to include a climate component in their submissions. Solutions across all five Hackathon tracks remain eligible, whether or not they address climate resilience or environmental issues.

Data and Testing restrictions

Applicants must use publicly available, synthetic, anonymised or expressly authorised data. No access to restricted electoral data, INEC production systems or other institutional systems is permitted without prior explicit written authorisation. Climate-related prototypes must not independently determine election outcomes, electoral validity or legal decisions. All solutions must comply with Hackathon's responsible AI, privacy, cybersecurity and human-oversight requirements.

7. PARTICIPANTS AND ELIGIBILITY

The programme will be open to eligible Nigerian and Africa-connected participants, including:

- University students, recent graduates and postgraduate researchers.
- All Participants must be of Nigerian Origin and must be at least 18 years old as of the commencement date of the deadline date of this Hackathon
- Software developers, AI engineers, data scientists and cybersecurity professionals.
- Academic researchers, lecturers and independent scholars.
- Startups, technology entrepreneurs and civic-tech innovators.
- Electoral experts, election observers and civil society practitioners.
- Product designers, accessibility specialists, linguists and communication researchers.
- Public-policy, governance, legal and data protection professionals.
- Emerging innovators and young people through a supervised youth pathway.

Requirements for Academia - At least one faculty lead, a student or post-grad researcher & cover letter of approval by the appropriate HOD in an accredited Institution within Nigeria.

Requirements for Start Ups/Organizations - Valid Registration Documents include CAC Certificate, no less than 60% team membership must be resident in Nigeria and Government ID for all team members.

Idea Only Proposals, Decks, Presentations, Research Papers, Applications submitted in any other Language apart from English, Applications submitted by non-Nigerians, Mockups, Projects that have already received any form of grants, awards or recognition in other previous competitions are ineligible in this Hackathon.

Applications may be submitted by teams of a minimum of 2 persons and no more than 4 Persons. Individual applicants will have an opportunity to participate in structured team matching. All Applications must be all submitted in English and each team member must register individually, satisfy all eligibility requirements, and be identified as part of the same team before the registration deadline. Entries submitted by teams will be judged as a single entry. Membership in Teams cannot be changed after the Hackathon begins. If a team entry is selected as a winner, the award will be made to the team collectively and will count as one of the three final winning teams. Winning Teams are expected to nominate their representative who will be best suited to represent them at the Grand Finale in person, and the Rise Networks judging panel will make the final determination.

The Hackathon seeks broad participation across Nigeria's six geopolitical zones, with targeted outreach to women, persons with disabilities, vulnerable groups, underserved communities and institutions outside major technology ecosystems. Secondary school participants will be considered through an age-appropriate, supervised youth category.

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8. COMPETITION DELIVERABLES

This is purely a *"Design + Develop"* only Competition. *Participants are expected to develop working solutions.* The principal competition deliverable is a working prototype or technically credible proof of concept addressing a defined electoral problem. Depending on the track, eligible outputs are expected to include:

- AI-enabled applications, tools and dashboards.
- Software prototypes, models and data-analysis pipelines.
- Research papers, policy briefs and technical methodologies.
- Accessible civic technology and multilingual information interfaces.
- Open-source components, technical documentation and evaluation frameworks.

Every competing team is required to demonstrate the problem it is addressing, explain its methodology, present evidence of functionality or technical feasibility, document limitations and outline the safeguards and conditions required for further testing. The programme will distinguish between concepts, prototypes, independently evaluated solutions and institutionally approved deployments. Winning a competition does not constitute approval for operational deployment.

9. KEY DATES

S/N	DATES	ACTIVITIES
1.	22nd October 2026	Applications Open
2.	12th November 2026	Applications Close at 11:59pm WAT
3.	October 2026	Public launch, partner engagement, participant registration and awareness campaign, Community outreach, onboarding, technical orientation and capacity-building sessions
4.	November 2026	Team formation, ideation, mentorship, technical development and prototype testing, solution refinement, judging, demonstrations and selection of finalists;
5.	December 2026	Grand finale, innovation showcase, presentation of awards and announcement of winning teams; and
6.	Jan/Feb 2027	Penetration & Usability testing during election cycle, continued public relations, impact reporting, technical mentorship, solution refinement, pilot discussions and potential acceleration support for selected teams.

Institutional partners are identified accurately, and their roles and logos are included only with written permission. Given the scheduled 2027 elections, the programme prioritises research, prototype development and controlled evaluation in the pre-election period. Any operational electoral deployment must comply with the relevant legal, institutional, technical and security approvals.

Duration of Activities

S/N	DATES	ACTIVITIES
1	22nd October	Application opens
2	12th November	Application closes
3	13th - 16th November 2026 (3 days)	Application data cleaning and eligibility checks
4	13th –16th November 2026 (3 days)	Technical and Programme screening of applications
5	13th - 16th November 2026 (3 days)	Shortlisting and notification of selected participants
6	18th - 19th - November 2026 (1 working day)	Participant onboarding and hackathon kick-off
7	23rd - 27th November 2026 (5 days)	Problem validation, ideation and solution design, Virtual technical bootcamp and mentor matching
8	28th November - 13th December 2026 (13days)	Prototype development sprint, testing & submission and documentation

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9	15th - 16th December 2026	Demo Day, Project showcase and Live Judging
10	16th December 2026	Grand finale, award presentation and innovation showcase

11. GRAND FINALE AND NATIONAL INNOVATION SHOWCASE

The Grand Finale & National Innovation Showcase is in Abuja in December 2026. Lagos will serve as the national convening location for the hackathon, technical demonstrations, innovation exhibition, final judging, awards and recognition of participants. A separate institutional and policy showcase in Abuja will be organized subsequently to present selected outcomes to relevant electoral institutions, public-sector stakeholders, research organizations and potential implementation partners during the National Grand Finale. The two-city approach is intended to combine a technology-focused national competition with sustained institutional engagement, without duplicating the main hackathon.

11. PRIZES AND AWARDS

The Total cash prize pool is **₦10million** for the overall winner, alongside awards for runners-up and specialist categories.

Position	**Award Category**	**Prize**
1st Place	Grand Prize - Overall Champion - Best overall AI-for-elections solution	₦4,000,000
2nd Place	Runner-up - Second-highest overall score	₦2,5000 ,000
3rd Place	Second Runner-up - Third-highest overall score	₦1,500,000

SPECIAL INNOVATION AWARDS

Award Category	**Description**	**Prize**
Research and Policy Innovation Award	Best misinformation detection, verification or electoral information solution	₦500,000
Electoral and Civic Inclusion Award	Best solution for accessibility, multilingual participation or underserved voters	₦500,000
Responsible AI and Safety Award	Best data-driven solution for electoral analysis or accountability	₦500,000
Cybersecurity and Resilience Award	Best solution addressing election-related digital security or system	₦500,000

WHAT WILL PARTICIPANTS GAIN?

Selected participants will have the opportunity to:

- **Compete for cash prizes:** Share in the **₦10 million** prize pool through the overall competition awards and special innovation awards and win Laptops and other Tech Devices.
- **Develop their technical skills:** Participate in virtual bootcamps, mentoring and technical workshops.
- **Pursue further development:** Promising teams may be considered for the **#AI4Elections Development Hub**, subject to selection, for further technical validation, product refinement and mentorship.
- **Build professional connections:** Join the **#AI4Elections Community of Practice**, connecting developers, researchers, universities, civic organizations, mentors and technology partners working on responsible electoral technology
- **Microsoft Azure Credits:** Access to Azure cloud credits to support prototyping, testing and development of their AI solutions, subject to applicable terms and allocation limits.

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The four special awards are open to teams across all challenge tracks. A team that wins an overall prize could also win a special award, provided it meets the criteria as that allows exceptional teams to receive more than one award while maintaining a transparent judging framework. Any other participating teams that did not win any of the top 3 Prizes are also eligible to win any of the four special awards.

Important Details

- Prize money will be awarded to winning teams. Each team is expected to identify a designated recipient and agree on how the funds will be distributed.
- The judging rubric will include technical quality, electoral relevance, innovation, feasibility, inclusion, privacy and responsible AI.
- The ₦10 Million in Prize Awards for the #AI4Elections Hackathon 2026 - 2027 prize pool is separate from the programme's budget for mentorship, cloud credits, incubation, resources, technical infrastructure, usability testing, pilot support and the grand finale. We believe the teams will need those resources to move their solutions beyond the competition. All prizes and in-kind benefits will be disclosed transparently, with final award values and conditions published before the competition.

In addition to cash prizes, the Hackathon may be able to provide access to:

- Laptops and development equipment.
- Cloud and AI compute credits.
- Software, API and developer-tool access.
- Technical mentorship and incubation.
- Research and product-development support.
- Opportunities for professional exposure and institutional engagement.

12. JUDGING AND EVALUATION CRITERIA

Projects will be evaluated using published criteria:

Criterion	Weight
Technical functionality and innovation	25%
Electoral relevance and practical usefulness	20%
Cybersecurity, privacy and responsible AI	20%
Inclusion, accessibility and multilingual capability	15%
Scalability, sustainability and feasibility	15%
Demonstration and documentation	5%
Total	**100%**

Research and youth categories may use adapted criteria appropriate to their deliverables and Judges will be selected for technical, electoral, academic, governance and civic expertise. Conflicts of interest must be disclosed, and judges will not score teams from which they stand to benefit or which they have materially mentored. Projects presenting critical security, privacy, safety or legal concerns may be excluded from awards or further testing, regardless of their technical score. The Council of Judges will comprise Six High Level Professionals including a Legal Expert, a Data/AI Expert, a Civil Society Expert, a Media Leader, an INEC official, a Cybersecurity expert.

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13. #AI4ELECTIONS DEVELOPMENT HUB

The #AI4Elections Development Hub will support a selected cohort of approximately two to four promising teams, subject to funding and mentor capacity. The incubation period is eight to twelve weeks and will be virtual. Support may include technical mentorship, code review, product development, access to compute resources, research collaboration, responsible-AI assessments, user research and potential introductions to institutions and funders. The Hub does not guarantee funding, procurement, institutional adoption or operational deployment. Any institutional pilot will require a written agreement, defined scope, relevant approvals and appropriate safeguards. The Hub will encourage a range of sustainable pathways, including independent startups, research collaborations, open-source projects, nonprofit initiatives and institutionally supported solutions.

14. #AI4ELECTIONS COMMUNITY OF PRACTICE AND NATIONAL REGISTRY

At the end of the Hackathon, Rise Networks will set up the #AI4Elections community of practice as a permanent national network for electoral technology and responsible AI. The community of practice will maintain a consent-based registry of participants, researchers, developers, mentors, institutions and alumni and its activities will include monthly technical and research sessions, quarterly project clinics, university chapters, mentorship, newsletters, research collaborations and annual innovation challenges. The registry will capture professional interests, skills, affiliations and preferred opportunities, with clear privacy notices, appropriate access controls and mechanisms for members to update or withdraw their information. The community of practice will support sustained collaboration and provide a talent and research pipeline for future public-interest technology initiatives.

15. GOVERNANCE AND PARTNERSHIPS

Rise Networks is the principal project initiator and secretariat. Its responsibilities are programme design, fundraising, partner coordination, application management, competition administration, community development, reporting and post-hackathon support.

Partner Category	Contribution
Electoral institutions	Subject-matter expertise, approved challenge inputs and technical engagement.
AI Experts and Firms	AI expertise, compute access, training, mentorship and technical resources.
Universities and research centres	Talent mobilisation, research, technical mentoring and evaluation.
Civil society and electoral research organisations	Electoral problem validation, civic expertise, inclusion and accountability.
Technology companies	Sponsorship, cloud credits, equipment, software, API access and technical support.
Development partners and foundations	Programme funding, inclusion, research, incubation and capacity development.

All institutional participation will be subject to appropriate approvals. Rise Networks will retain responsibility for programme governance, while each partner will retain control of its own systems, data, policies and deployment decisions.

16. TECHNICAL SAFEGUARDS, DATA PROTECTION, ETHICS AND RESPONSIBLE AI GUIDELINES

The Hackathon will operate under the following principles:

- Non - Partisanship and equal treatment of participants.
- Respect for electoral law, fundamental rights and freedom of expression.
- No Partisan voter persuasion, political microtargeting or manipulation of electoral participation.
- No unauthorised access to or testing of live electoral systems.
- Use of synthetic, public or explicitly authorised datasets.
- Protection of personal information and confidential institutional data.

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- Human oversight of consequential decisions and clear documentation of model limitations.
- Accessibility and inclusion in programme design and technology development.
- Transparent prize rules, intellectual property terms and conflict-of-interest management.

All teams will be required to sign a participant code of conduct and comply with the published technical and data-use rules and all solutions developed under the #AI4Elections Hackathon 2026 - 2027 must be designed, developed, tested and demonstrated in accordance with responsible-AI principles, applicable laws and regulations, and the technical safeguards established by Rise Networks and any authorised institutional partners. These requirements apply to all five challenge tracks and are mandatory for every participating team.

7.1 Responsible and Human-Centred AI

Solutions must be designed to support, rather than replace, human judgement, legally authorised electoral processes and institutional decision-making. AI-generated outputs, classifications, predictions, recommendations and analytical findings must be presented transparently, with appropriate explanations of their intended use, limitations and potential for error. No solution may independently declare election results, determine the legal validity of votes, make authoritative findings of electoral fraud, or substitute algorithmic outputs for decisions reserved for INEC, courts or other legally authorised institutions.

7.2 Data Protection and Privacy

Participants must comply with applicable data-protection and privacy legislation, including the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 and any applicable institutional data-governance requirements. Only publicly available, synthetic, anonymised, aggregated or expressly authorised datasets may be used. Participants must not collect, process, disclose, transfer or retain personal or sensitive information without a lawful basis, appropriate safeguards and any required permissions. The use of voter registers, biometric information, personal voter records or other restricted electoral data is prohibited unless expressly authorised through the relevant lawful and institutional approval processes. Teams must apply data minimisation, secure storage, access controls and appropriate data-retention and deletion practices.

7.3 Data Integrity, Transparency and Explainability

Participants must identify the sources of datasets used, document relevant assumptions and disclose material limitations, including missing, incomplete, biased or potentially inaccurate information. AI-generated information must not be knowingly presented as verified fact without appropriate validation. Solutions must provide reasonable transparency regarding how information is processed and how users should interpret outputs. Where a system produces a risk assessment, classification, recommendation or alert, the basis and limitations of that output must be documented and made available for human review.

7.4 Fairness, Accessibility and Inclusion

Solutions must be developed with due regard for accessibility, inclusion, language diversity and the risk of unfair or discriminatory outcomes. Teams should consider the needs of persons with disabilities, citizens with limited digital literacy, users of Nigerian languages and communities with limited access to digital infrastructure. Where feasible, prototypes should be tested with representative users and assessed for usability, accessibility and unintended exclusion.

7.5 Cybersecurity and Technical Safety

All solutions must incorporate appropriate security controls proportionate to their intended use, including secure development practices, access management, protection of credentials, secure handling of data and vulnerability remediation. Participants must not attempt to access, probe, scan, disrupt, interfere with or test any system, infrastructure, network, application, database or digital service without the express written authorisation of its owner or responsible authority. All technical testing

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must be conducted in approved development environments, isolated sandboxes, synthetic-data environments or other expressly authorised settings.

7.6 Human Oversight and Accountability

Teams must identify the human roles responsible for reviewing outputs, managing errors, responding to complaints and addressing potential harms. Solutions must not be designed to make consequential electoral determinations or trigger consequential actions without appropriate human oversight and authorisation. Teams must maintain sufficient documentation to support technical evaluation, independent review and responsible use.

7.7 Testing, Demonstration and Institutional Engagement

All prototypes must be demonstrated and evaluated within the scope of the Hackathon's approved technical and operational boundaries. Participation in the Hackathon, including any technical feedback or observation by Rise Networks, its partners or another institution, does not confer access to institutional systems, restricted data, production environments or internal infrastructure. Any subsequent institutional evaluation, pilot, procurement, adoption or deployment shall require separate written authorization and compliance with applicable legal, technical, cybersecurity, privacy, procurement and administrative requirements.

7.8 Compliance and Consequences of Breach

Rise Networks reserves the right to request documentation, review prototype functionality, require corrective action, restrict testing activities or disqualify any team that violates these requirements. Serious or deliberate breaches, including unauthorised system access, misuse of personal data, unlawful disclosure of restricted information or interference with electoral infrastructure, may result in immediate disqualification and referral to the relevant authorities where appropriate.

By participating in the Hackathon, all teams agree to comply with these requirements and any additional safeguards formally communicated by Rise Networks or authorised institutional partners.

17. MONITORING, EVALUATION AND LEARNING

The Hackathon will measure performance across participation, innovation, capacity development, community growth and post-event outcomes. The First-edition planning targets include:

Indicator	Target
Applications	100 – 250 teams
Universities represented	Minimum of 10
Teams selected for the programme	25 – 40
Finalist projects	20
Incubation cohort	7
Community members	500+

Additional indicators include diversity of participation, prototype functionality, completion of technical reviews, post-event team retention, mentorship engagement, research outputs and potential institutional pilots. Rise Networks will produce an inaugural outcome report documenting participation, projects, awards, lessons learned, responsible-AI assessments and recommendations for future editions. In-kind contributions such as cloud credits, laptops, equipment, venue support and professional services will be separately documented and will not be represented as cash funding.

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18. INSTITUTIONAL ALIGNMENT, ENGAGEMENT AND NON-ENDORSEMENT

The #AI4Elections Hackathon 2026 - 2027, organised by Rise Networks, welcomes technical guidance, subject-matter expertise and institutional input from the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) and other relevant stakeholders to support the development of responsible, practical and human-centred technological solutions for electoral and civic processes in Nigeria. The Programme recognises INEC's constitutional and statutory responsibilities in the administration of elections and seeks to complement broader efforts to improve voter education, electoral information access, accessibility, public understanding, operational efficiency and citizen engagement through responsible innovation.

Where INEC or any other institution agrees to support, its engagement may include contributing to the development or review of non-sensitive challenge statements, provide technical or operational insights, participating in orientation sessions, observing demonstrations, or offering feedback on selected solutions, subject to the institution's internal approvals, availability and applicable requirements. All institutional participation shall be voluntary and subject to the relevant institution's statutory mandate, administrative procedures, technical requirements and approval processes. Participation, consultation, technical input, observation or feedback by INEC or any other institution shall not constitute or imply institutional endorsement, certification, procurement commitment, approval for deployment, or an obligation to adopt, pilot, fund or otherwise utilise any solution developed through the Hackathon. All participating teams shall independently comply with the Programme's eligibility requirements, judging criteria, responsible AI safeguards and applicable legal and regulatory obligations.

Any subsequent evaluation, pilot, procurement, adoption or deployment of a solution by INEC or another institution shall be subject to separate formal consideration and all applicable technical, cybersecurity, privacy, data-protection, legal, procurement and administrative approvals. The Hackathon is a nonpartisan public-interest innovation initiative. It does not promote or endorse any political party, candidate, electoral outcome or partisan interest.

Relevant Institutional Experience

It is worthy of note that Rise Networks has previously collaborated with the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) on technology and electoral information integrity initiatives. With funding support from the MacArthur Foundation, Rise Networks developed Nigeria's first AI-powered mobile application for misinformation detection and factchecking, with the active participation and engagement of INEC in the initiative. See www.vanguardngr.com/2023/01/elections-nigerian-coy-unveil-app-to-combat-fake-news and www.thisdaylive.com/2023/01/22/inec-macarthur-synergise-to-tackle-fake-news-doctored-videos This previous experience provides an important foundation for the #AI4Elections Programme and demonstrates our practical experience of working with electoral institutions to develop responsible technology solutions addressing misinformation, public information and electoral integrity.

19. CONCLUSION

The #AI4Elections Hackathon represents an opportunity to connect Nigeria's technology talent with the needs of electoral integrity, inclusion and democratic participation. Through the combined strengths of competition, incubation and community-building, Rise Networks will create a platform where technical talent and electoral expertise can collaborate to develop practical, responsible and evidence-based solutions for Nigeria's electoral and democratic processes.

This inaugural edition will serve as the foundation for a recurring national initiative that supports AI talent development, public-interest innovation, independent research and constructive engagement with electoral stakeholders. Rise Networks welcomes partnerships with institutions and individuals committed to responsible electoral technology, electoral integrity, inclusion and democratic participation.

Technical Briefs, Documentation & Resources for all Teams available at - https://github.com/Rise-Networks-AI-Labs/-AI4Elections-Hackathon

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